GALERA REAL

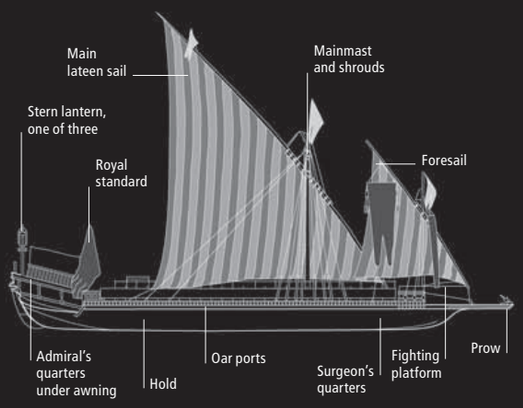
THE GALERA REAL was no ordinary war galley, but a luxury vessel made for Don John of Austria, commander-in-chief of the fleet of the Holy League assembled to fight the Ottoman Turks. A gift from his half-brother, King Philip II of Spain, the galley was built in the shipyards of Barcelona in 1568, then decorated and gilded in Seville.

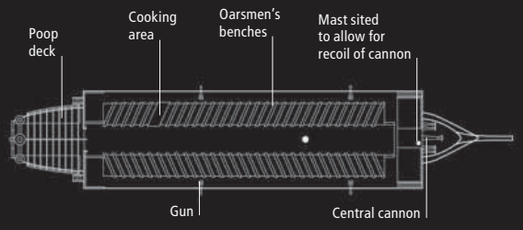
THE PALATIAL ROYAL FLAGSHIP was 197 ft (60 m) long and 24 ft (6.2 m) wide and carried a crew of as many as 400 men. Of these, 236 were required simply to row the galley, with four men manning each oar. In addition, there were a number of skilled sailors to steer and manage the two lateen sails, as well as a large detachment of soldiers. The galley was armed with a large central cannon in the bow, flanked by four medium-sized guns. There were also four much smaller guns sited between the oarsmen's stations, two on each side of the ship.

This replica of the galley was made for the Maritime Museum in Barcelona to mark the 400th anniversary of the Holy League's victory at the battle of Lepanto on October 7, 1571. The ship's most striking feature is the sheer richness of its decoration, from the figurehead of Neptune to the paintings and statues on the stern. These were painstakingly recreated from a description written at the time. Many of them feature the Classical heroes Hercules and Jason. The choice of these two figures was significant: in his quest for the Golden Fleece Jason sailed with the Argonauts to Colchis on the Black Sea, while legend placed the Pillars of Hercules at the Strait of Gibraltar—the two extremes of the vast length of coastline controlled by the Ottoman Empire.

In action at Lepanto
Don John's galley fought a close-quarters duel with the Ottoman flagship *Sultana*. Turkish soldiers boarded the galley, but were driven back.

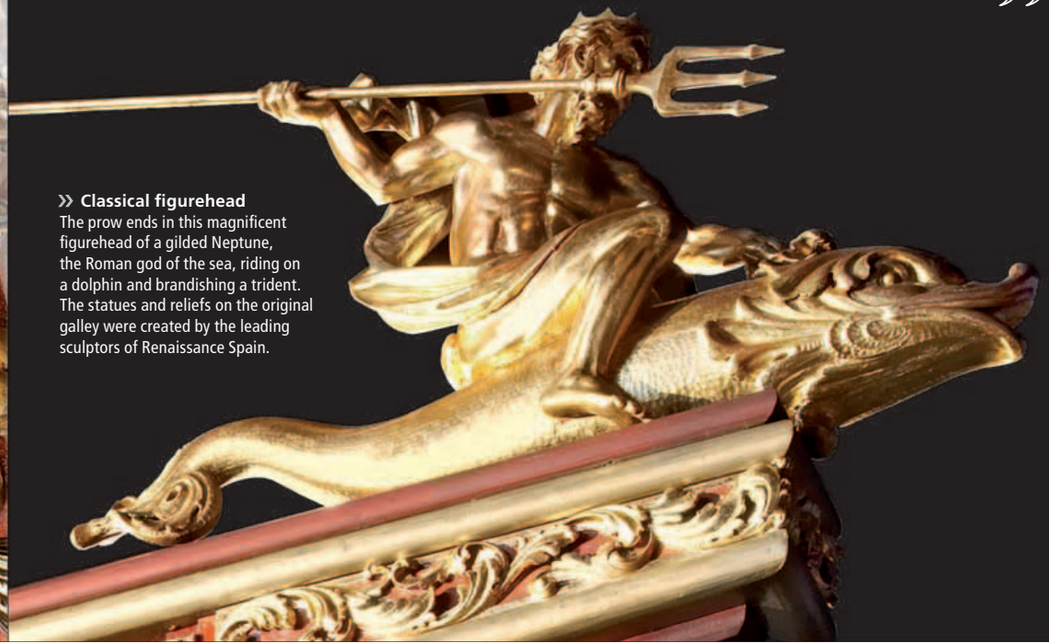




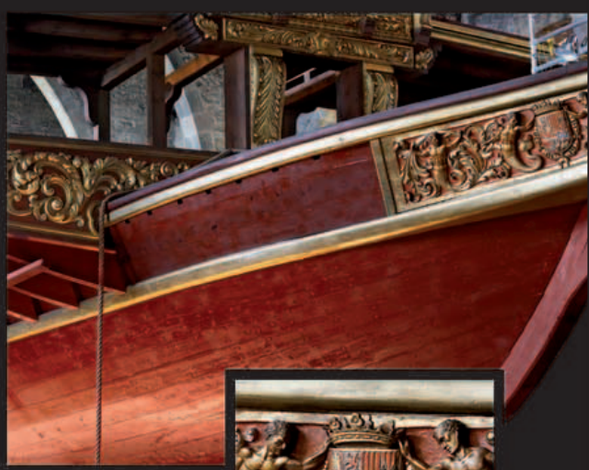


Galera Real
The galley raised its sails when crossing open sea with a favorable wind, but in battle relied on its 236 oarsmen. The main battle tactic was to board and capture enemy ships.

> "THE GREAT BANNER OF THE LEAGUE, DISPLAYING CHRIST CRUCIFIED, ... THE COATS OF ARMS OF HABSBURG SPAIN, THE POPE, AND THE REPUBLIC OF VENICE, WAS HOISTED ON THE REAL'S MAINMAST."
>
> **NICCOLÒ CAPPONI** DESCRIBING THE OPENING OF THE BATTLE OF LEPANTO



» **Classical figurehead**
The prow ends in this magnificent figurehead of a gilded Neptune, the Roman god of the sea, riding on a dolphin and brandishing a trident. The statues and reliefs on the original galley were created by the leading sculptors of Renaissance Spain.





» **Prow**
The galley's long prow is decorated with the coat of arms of Philip II of Spain, supported by two mermen. Before Lepanto Don John had the end of the prow cut off so that the central cannon could be depressed to shoot down on the Ottoman ships.